

Project XTC

Working Paper 007

Chapter 7 – The V-Pots: The Chameleons of the X-Touch

If the motor faders are the muscles of the X-Touch, the V-Pots are its fingertips. No other control changes role as frequently, or contributes more to the feeling that the controller is responding intelligently to whatever you are doing.

What is a V-Pot?

Each channel strip contains a rotary encoder with an illuminated LED ring. Unlike a traditional potentiometer, a V-Pot has no fixed start or end point. It can be turned forever in either direction, making it ideal for controlling many different parameters.

The LED Ring

The LEDs surrounding each V-Pot are not decorative. They provide immediate feedback about the current value. Depending on the parameter, DrivenByMoss may display a full bar, a single position marker or a centred pattern for values that have a natural midpoint, such as pan.

One Knob – Hundreds of Jobs

In Mixer mode the V-Pots commonly adjust pan. Switch to Sends mode and the same controls adjust send levels. Enter Device mode and they become parameter controls for the selected Bitwig device or plug-in. Browser mode transforms them again into navigation controls.

Why?

The V-Pot is an example of why the X-Touch scales so well. Eight encoders are enough to control hundreds of parameters because the software decides which eight are currently the most useful. Rather than giving you hundreds of knobs, DrivenByMoss gives you the right eight.

Tip

When exploring a new Bitwig device, glance at the scribble strips before turning a V-Pot. They tell you exactly which parameter each encoder is about to change.

Common Mistake

'The V-Pots have stopped controlling pan!'

They almost certainly haven't. You've probably entered another mode. Before assuming something is wrong, ask yourself: Which mode am I in?

Exercise

Load Bitwig's Polymer synthesiser. Select the track, enter Device mode and slowly turn each V-Pot while watching both the scribble strips and the LED rings. Notice how the hardware, display and software all change together to form a single instrument panel.